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SECRET RENDEZVOUS

The shooting down of the U-2 airplane piloted by Major Anderson became a turning point in the deliberations that President Kennedy and his advisers conducted that day. Robert Kennedy later suggested that the news changed the atmosphere in the Cabinet Room of the White House. “There was sympathy for Major Anderson and his family,” wrote Robert. “There was the knowledge that we had to take military action to protect our pilots. There was the realization that the Soviet Union and Cuba apparently were preparing to do battle. And there was the feeling that the noose was tightening on all of us, on Americans, on mankind, and that the bridges to escape were crumbling.”[1]

What, then, was to be done in that situation? “They have fired the first shot,” said Paul Nitze. General Taylor proposed to retaliate by destroying the missile site that had shot down the plane and following up with a general strike if shooting at other planes continued. “It’s what we agreed to do two days ago,” said the general. “It looked good then, and it still looks